inspected these men himself. Every evening, as the Qur* was taken in to the diwan-e-khas, the golden lion on the pennant glowing in the fast-falling dusk, Akbar would inspect the two rows of guards standing on either side of the hall. On the right were the guards who had done guard duty all day and on the left were guards who would relieve them, ready for night duty. Both ranks of men would salute smartly as the Padshah appeared, and Akbar would stop to inspect each man, his sharp eyes noting any uniform that was awry or any guard who was missing. Absentees, unless excused with a valid reason, were fined a week's pay.

The evening then ended sometimes with horse polo using, as we have seen earlier, wooden balls that were set alight to smoulder in the dark. The ends of the chaugan or polo sticks were made of gold and silver and if they broke during a game, the players were allowed to keep them. There were other diversions and entertainments at hand including 'elephant-fighting, buffalo-fighting, stag-fighting, and cock-fighting, boxing contests, battles of gladiators, and the flying of tumbler-pigeons'. Late at night Akbar would finally retire, for a few short hours of sleep. In the very early dawn, as the last stars were fading from the night sky, soldiers, merchants, peasants and townsfolk would begin to shuffle up to and gather below the jharoka window, preparing to bow before the glorious presence of the Padshah, immutable and consoling, ready to begin a new day.

*The *Razmnama*, along with other priceless documents, have been sealed by court order and it is unknown what condition they are now in.

*Keshavdas Misra of Orchha was a pre-eminent Brajbhasha poet. An heir to the Sanskrit tradition, he is credited by scholars with influencing Braj poetry with classical inflection and is also celebrated as being a major influence in the efflorescence of poetry in the language.

*A collection of flags and royal insignia.